The 5 Steps of Lectio Divina ("Sacred" or "Divine" Reading of Scripture):

The Church "forcefully and specially exhorts all the Christian faithful. . . to learn 'the surpassing knowledge of Jesus Christ' (Phil 3:8) by frequent reading of the divine Scriptures. . . . Let them remember, however, that prayer should accompany the reading of Sacred Scripture, so that a dialogue takes place between God and man. For 'we speak to him when we pray; we listen to him when we read the divine oracles'." (*Catechism of the Catholic Church* 2653; *Dei Verbum* 25)

Before you begin, ask the Holy Spirit to open your mind and your heart to guide your time in prayer.

1) Reading *(lectio)*: Read and re-read the text you have chosen.
Ask: What does the Biblical text say in itself?

2) Meditation *(meditatio)*: Reflect upon the words and meanings found in the text.
Ask: What does the Biblical text say to you?

3) Prayer *(oratio)*: Respond to the text you read with words of prayer to the Lord.
Ask: What do you say to the Lord in response to His word?

4) Contemplation *(contemplatio)*: Rest in this gift from the Lord and begin to see the world as God sees it.
Ask: What conversion of mind, heart and life is the Lord asking of you?

5) Action *(actio)*: Resolve to act on the inspirations you receive in prayer.
Ask: What can you do to make your life a gift for others in charity?

In conclusion, thank the Holy Spirit for all the graces that have been poured out upon you during this time.

[Text adapted from *Verbum Domini* (paragraphs 86-87).]

Verbum Domini, 86: The Synod frequently insisted on the need for a prayerful approach to the sacred text as a fundamental element in the spiritual life of every believer, in the various ministries and states in life, with particular reference to *lectio divina*. The word of God is at the basis of all authentic Christian spirituality.

St. John Chrysostom, Homilies on St. Matthew, II: Which of you, I ask, if requested to recite a psalm is able to do so, or any other part of Sacred Scripture? In truth, none of you! And that is not the worst of it; for in fact you are lazy concerning spiritual matters…And what is your defense against such an accusation? You respond: I am not a monk; rather I have a wife and children and I need to take care of my domestic responsibilities. Yet precisely for that reason everything is going awry: for you have persuaded yourselves that only monks should be concerned with *Lectio Divina*, when in fact you need it more than they do. Those that walk in the open fields and receive wounds each day are those who most need medicine.

Navigating the "C"s of Prayer:
Lectio Divina according to the method of St. Teresa of Avila

1. Come into presence of God

- Pray that God will show you what he wants you to see in the passage.

2. Choose the passage *[Lectio]*

- Read it once through, then read it again slowly, pausing on any word(s) that jump out at you.

3. Capture the scene/Characters/Context *[Meditatio]*

- Look at the context. What are the passages before and after the passage that you are reading about? This will give you greater insight into the passage that you are reading.
- Put yourself there. Use your imagination.
- Ask yourself the questions: Who, what, where, how?
- What do they look like? What does it smell like (ex. prodigal son in swine pin)? Where are you standing? Who do you relate to the most in the story?
- What is the tension in this passage?

4. Contemplation/Conversation *[Oratio/Contemplatio]*

- Talk to God. Tell him what you're thinking, feeling, what you thought of his teaching, his miracle, or whatever it is that you have read.
- Ask God what he wants to tell you now, for the situation that you are in today.
- Ask God how this applies to your life. What needs to change in my life?
- Listen. This is the hardest, but more important, step. Listen to what God is saying to you.

5. Conclusion—firm resolution to Change *[Actio]*

- Thank God for this time you got to spend together.
- Ask God for the grace to change what he wants to change in you.
- Come up with a phrase/prayer/resolution you want to keep for that day. Focus on that particular day. This can be a word or statement someone made in the passage, i.e. "Help me not to be afraid," "please calm the storms going on in my life"—say this prayer throughout the day whenever you remember.
- Close in an Our Father asking God to let you see how much he loves you and to be faithful to your resolution.